

DESIGNER

YVES ST LAURENT

A giant of 20th-century international fashion, French designer Yves Saint Laurent dominated the 1960s and 70s. He deftly juggled street style and traditional tailoring, revolutionized the female wardrobe by popularizing women's trousers, and raised the status of ready-to-wear clothes.

After winning an international fashion competition, a teenaged Saint Laurent studied fashion in Paris. Having seen some of his sketches, leading legend Christian Dior hired the prodigy as an assistant.

Fashion's enfant terrible

When Dior died, in 1957, Saint Laurent became Dior's creative head, and at 21 the world's youngest couturier. His first solo collection was *Trapeze* (1958) – short, trapezoid dresses that swung from narrow shoulders and echoed his mentor's A-lines. However, his rebellious “beatnik” collection (1960), inspired by a love of Paris's Left Bank clubs and jazz bars, sparked criticism. Appalled by the collection's street-wise black turtlenecks and leather biker-style jackets, Dior acted swiftly when Saint Laurent was drafted into the army in 1960 and replaced him with Marc Bohan. After his discharge from the army, Saint Laurent successfully sued Dior for unfair dismissal and set up his own *maison*, showing his first collection in 1962.

Early collections featured pea coats and smocks – further high-end reinventions of street style. The 1960s brought the shock of the cross-gender *Le smoking* tuxedo suit for evening wear, as well as making trouser suits a daily womenswear staple; variants included knickerbockers and culottes. Saint Laurent's love of art exploded in the mid 1960s: colour-block dresses (1965–66) inspired by Mondrian's paintings and the *Pop Art* collection (1966).

From hippies to disco

By the late 1960s Saint Laurent had shown his famous safari jackets and suits for women (and men), thigh-high boots, controversial see-through blouses, and an *African* collection (1967) inspired by ethnic motifs. He pioneered the referencing of other cultures and was the first designer to feature African and Asian runway models, his multicultural interests greatly influencing hippie fashions. There were dresses featuring exotic feathers (1969–70), and patchworked fur coats, alongside glamorous evening gowns. His 1940s-inspired, square-shouldered *Libération* collection (1971) offended some with its reminders of German occupation but made a huge mark on the 1970s. The watershed *Opéra-Ballets Russes* collection (1976) offered “peasant chic”. Mixing larger shapes and gemlike colours, its luxurious notes chimed with the growing hedonistic US disco scene and helped define 1980s couture.

The empire changes

Through the 1980s and 90s Saint Laurent consolidated both his classic styles and an empire embracing fragrances, cosmetics, home linens, accessories, the all-important ready-to-wear lines and shops, and stylish menswear. In 1999 Gucci bought the YSL ready-to-wear line and made Tom Ford its designer (1999–2004). Ford paid homage to many YSL classics, while his successor, Stefano Pilati, favoured a sharp chic. Hedi Slimane, former designer at Dior Homme, took over in 2012.

Saint Laurent closed the couture business and retired in 2002. His promotion of the timeless classic remains a major legacy, while YSL motifs crop up constantly in the collections of younger designers, such as the tuxedo styles of Stella McCartney.



△ **YSL**
Yves Saint Laurent outside his first London boutique in the late 1960s. Couture's “bad boy” was much influenced by Paris's Left Bank scene and used the name Rive Gauche for all his boutiques and ready-to-wear collections.

◁ TROUSER REVOLUTION

Until Saint Laurent dared to change everything, women were sometimes refused entry to restaurants for wearing trousers. This glamorous suit featured in his 1979 Spring/Summer collection.



TIMELINE

1936 Born in Oran, Algeria

1957–58 At 21 takes over at Dior, when Christian Dior dies. Presents A-line *Trapeze* look at successful first collection

1962 Launches own fashion house

▷ 1965–66 Creates much-copied “Mondrian” colour-block dresses. First Rive Gauche boutique opens in Paris

1976 *Opéra-Ballet Russes* couture-peasant collection hits front page of *New York Times*

1971 *Libération* collection reinvents a big-shouldered 1940s silhouette

▷ 1998 Dress worn at opening of the YSL Room at the National Gallery, London

1999 Sells YSL to Gucci

2008 Dies in Paris

○ 1930

○ 1960

○ 1970

○ 1990

○ 2000